Indian security agencies, agree on this point. Could India have adopted a different approach to the hijacking episode to reconcile these two dilemmas? According to Dixit, New Delhi had the option to refuse direct negotiations with the hijackers, and let the Taliban sort the situation and take responsibility.[144] This was not feasible because India had not recognised the Taliban. Any attempt to allow the Taliban to handle the crisis would require political recognition, something that the Taliban wanted. Two, even if India recognised the Taliban politically, the latter could have simply stated the hijackers demands to New Delhi and left it at that—it was a risk at the least. Either way, India would have had to contact the Taliban. To be clear, this policy dilemma over negotiating with the hijackers, which had their own coalitions, was context-specific and had only an indirect link to the larger debate between the partisans and the conciliators. India's limited engagement with the Taliban, in this context, does not automatically imply a change in its larger policy approach vis-à-vis the Taliban. In effect, India's policy of non-engagement with the Taliban did not change.

Does this mean that there was no real debate over the Taliban question after the IC-814 incident? Though not in public given how emotive the topic was (and still is), debate between the partisans and the conciliators continued. With a strategic failure staring them in the face, the question of how to develop India's presence in the Pashtun-dominated areas of south and east Afghanistan gained salience in New Delhi's strategic circles. Focus on the UF had paid little dividends during the IC-814 crisis, while Pakistan achieved a strategic coup. The contours of the debate, however, underwent a change. While the partisans started pointing towards political and tribal nuances within Pashtuns, the conciliators grudgingly accepted the limited reach India can possibly have even if it tried to cultivate ties with the Taliban. Who were the conciliators in office at that time? Based on multiple interviews, personal memoirs, and crosschecks it can be established that Jaswant Singh, Brajesh Mishra, Vajpayee, Dulat, and Dixit were some of the key conciliators during and after the hijacking.

These conciliators advocated direct communication channels with the Taliban, if not outright political recognition. According to some, Singh's unilateral decision to fly to Kandahar had a political purpose, which was to open that channel of communication with the Taliban.[145] Jaswant Singh concurs that